

ROBSON PEDROSA COSTA

Historian of Slavery, Gender, and the Atlantic World

Professor, Instituto Federal de Brasília (IFB), Brazil

Collaborative Researcher, Centre for History, University of Lisbon, Portugal | Faculty Member, Graduate Program in History, UFPE, Brazil

Research Areas: Slavery and Emancipation · Slave-owning Slaves · Gender and Women's History · African Diaspora · Atlantic History · Religion and Slavery · Brazil and Africa · Resistance and Freedom

Lattes: <http://lattes.cnpq.br/6375934645076409>

RESEARCH PROFILE

Robson Pedrosa Costa is a historian specializing in slavery, gender, and the Atlantic World, with particular interests in Brazil, Africa, and the African diaspora. His current research focuses especially on the histories and experiences of African and Afro-descendant women, examining slavery, resistance, freedom, motherhood, family, mobility, religion, and the multiple connections linking Africa and the diaspora. His broader scholarship also addresses institutional slavery, religion, paternalism, emancipation, and slave-owning slaves in Africa and Brazil.

He is the author of *Paternalism, Transgression and Slave Resistance in Brazil* (De Gruyter Oldenbourg, 2022). His scholarship has received international recognition including the Kimberly S. Hanger Article Prize, an Honorable Mention from the Brazilian Studies Association (BRASA), and the Toni Bambara Article Prize. He was a Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions Postdoctoral Fellow at the University of Lisbon (2022–2024) and currently leads collaborative international research on women, slavery, Africa, and the African diaspora.

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS & AFFILIATIONS

Instituto Federal de Brasília (IFB), Brazil

Professor, 2026–present

Centre for History, University of Lisbon, Portugal

Collaborative Researcher (Investigador Colaborador), 2025–present

Graduate Program in History, Federal University of Pernambuco (UFPE), Brazil

Permanent Faculty Member, 2020–present

Instituto Federal de Pernambuco (IFPE), Brazil

Professor, 2012–2026

Centre for History, University of Lisbon, Portugal

Assistant Researcher / Marie Skłodowska-Curie Postdoctoral Fellow, 2022–2024

EDUCATION & POSTDOCTORAL TRAINING

University of Lisbon, Portugal

Postdoctoral Research Fellowship in History, 2022–2024

Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions (MSCA), Horizon Europe

Federal University of Pernambuco (UFPE), Brazil

PhD in History, 2013

Dissertation: *A Ordem de São Bento e os escravos do Santo, Pernambuco, séculos XVIII e XIX.*

Federal University of Pernambuco (UFPE), Brazil

MA in History, 2007

Thesis: *Cotidiano e resistência nas últimas décadas da escravidão, Olinda, 1871–1888.*

Federal University of Pernambuco (UFPE), Brazil

BA in History, 2004

FELLOWSHIPS, GRANTS & FUNDED RESEARCH

Women of Africa, Women of the Diaspora: Connections, Transgressions and Resistance

Principal Investigator, 2025–present | CNPq/MCTI/FNDCT Call No. 22/2024 – Programa Conhecimento Brasil

International collaborative project connecting researchers in Brazil and abroad and investigating African and diasporic women through slavery, freedom, gender, intersectionality, family, motherhood, religion, resistance, mobility, and the slave trades.

SLAVESRELIGION – Slaves of Religion: Paternalism and Resistance, Brazil

Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions Postdoctoral Fellowship, University of Lisbon, 2022–2024 | Horizon Europe

Research on slavery in properties belonging to religious institutions, based partly on extensive archival research in Portugal. A second research phase continues from 2025.

History, Memory and Innovation: Anti-Racist Education, Ancestral Knowledge and Digital Technologies

Funded Research and Outreach Project, 2022–2023 | FACEPE

Project connecting historical research, ethnic-racial education, digital technologies, Afro-Brazilian memory and heritage, and engagement with traditional communities.

Pernambuco em cores, falas e escritas: um olhar multifacetado sobre o passado e o presente

Funded Innovation Project, 2018–2019 | FACEPE

Interdisciplinary public-history exhibition connecting past and present through slavery, memory, heritage, and multisensory approaches.

AWARDS & HONORS

Toni Bambara Article Prize

Black Women's Studies Association (BWSA), 2026

For “Mum Told Me All About Her Ancestors: Milonga, Ancestry, and Women’s Legal Resistance to Slavery, Belgian Congo, 1908–1960.”

Honorable Mention, Best Article Prize

Brazilian Studies Association (BRASA), 2025

For “Maria Simoa, Who Birthed Twenty-Four Children: Slavery, Motherhood, and Freedom on the Benedictine Estates, Pernambuco, Brazil, 1866–1871.”

Kimberly S. Hanger Article Prize

Latin American and Caribbean Section, Southern Historical Association (LACS-SHA), 2024

For “Maria Simoa, Who Birthed Twenty-Four Children...”

Seal of Excellence

European Commission, 2021

Certificate awarded to a high-quality research proposal in a highly competitive assessment process.

Seal of Excellence

European Commission, 2020

Seal of Excellence

European Commission, 2019

PUBLICATIONS

Books and Edited Volumes

Edited Volumes in Preparation

African and Afro-descendant Women: History, Culture, and Connections between Africa and Brazil. Edited volume in preparation.

Women and Slavery: Violence, Resistance and Diasporas. Edited volume in preparation.

Costa, Robson Pedrosa, Suely C. C. Almeida, and Marcos P. Costa. *Escravidão e resistência feminina: contribuições para o ensino de história através de documentos*. Porto Alegre: Editora Fi, 2024. Open Access.

Costa, Robson Pedrosa, Wanessa Gomes, and Dimas Brasileiro Veras, eds. *História, memória e saberes ancestrais: uma proposta inovadora para uma luta antirracista*. Porto Alegre: Editora Fi, 2024. Open Access.

Costa, Robson Pedrosa. *Paternalism, Transgression and Slave Resistance in Brazil*. Berlin: De Gruyter Oldenbourg, 2022.

- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. *Os Escravos do Santo: uma história sobre paternalismo e transgressão nas propriedades beneditinas, nos séculos XVIII e XIX*. Recife: Editora da UFPE, 2020. Open Access.
- Cabral, Flávio José Gomes, and Robson Pedrosa Costa, eds. *História da escravidão em Pernambuco*. Recife: Editora da UFPE, 2012.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. *Vozes na Senzala: cotidiano e resistência nas últimas décadas da escravidão, Olinda, 1871–1888*. Recife: Editora Universitária da UFPE, 2008.

Articles Accepted for Publication / Forthcoming

- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Slaves-owning slaves: rethinking a concept.” *Revista de Indias*. Forthcoming, 2026. Slave-owning Slaves
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Slaves-owning slaves: a peculiar African institution.” *Topoi: Revista de História*. Forthcoming, 2026. Slave-owning Slaves

Peer-Reviewed Articles

- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “‘Uma eugenia astuciosa?’ Maternidade, casamento e miscigenação em propriedades beneditinas, séculos XVII e XVIII.” *Varia Historia* 41 (2025): 1–36.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “‘Mum Told Me All About Her Ancestors’: Milonga, Ancestry, and Women’s Legal Resistance to Slavery, Belgian Congo, 1908–1960.” *Slavery & Abolition* 46 (2025): 725–740. **Winner, Toni Bambara Article Prize**
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa, and Cassia Roth. “Maria Simoa, Who Birthed Twenty-Four Children: Slavery, Motherhood, and Freedom on the Benedictine Estates, Pernambuco, Brazil, 1866–1871.” *Hispanic American Historical Review* 103 (2023): 65–99. **Kimberly S. Hanger Article Prize; BRASA Honorable Mention**
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa, and Suely C. C. Almeida. “A tramoia de Maria de Jesus e os caminhos da Justiça no Brasil escravista no século XVIII.” *Ler História* 81 (2022): 93–116.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “‘Sweet Masters’: The Order of Saint Benedict and the ‘Good Treatment’ of Slaves, Brazil, Eighteenth and Nineteenth Centuries.” *Historia Crítica* (2021): 21–47.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Nicolau de Souza: the trajectory of a slave-owning slave, Brazil, 1812–1835.” *Forum Historiae Iuris* 1 (2021): 1–22. Slave-owning Slaves
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Escravos senhores de escravos. Pernambuco, séculos XVIII e XIX.” *História & Perspectivas* 57 (2018): 149–176. Slave-owning Slaves
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Rufina: uma escrava senhora de escravos em Pernambuco, 1853–1862.” *Revista Brasileira de História* 38 (2018): 109–130. Slave-owning Slaves
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Um senhor de escravo em cativo: a trajetória de Nicolau de Souza, Pernambuco, 1812–1835.” *Territórios e Fronteiras* 10 (2017): 47.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Os monges emancipadores: a Ordem de São Bento e suas estratégias de liberação dos escravos, 1866–1871.” *Revista Latino-Americana de História* 4 (2015): 27–48.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “O caráter senhorial beneditino. Pernambuco, séculos XVIII e XIX.” *Religare* 11 (2014): 317–342.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “A Igreja Católica e a Escravidão Negra: revisitando uma polêmica.” *Interfaces de Saberes* 9 (2009): 1–18.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “‘Cativos Indolentes’: o cotidiano do trabalho escravo no século XIX em Olinda (1871–1888).” *Clio. Série História do Nordeste* 25 (2007): 323–347.

Selected Book Chapters

- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “‘Mum Told Me All About Her Ancestors’: Milonga, Ancestry, and Women’s Legal Resistance to Slavery, Belgian Congo, 1908–1960.” In *Resistance to Slavery in Africa Past and Present*, edited by Marie Rodet, Lotte Pelckmans, Wayne Dooling, and Esteban Salas. London: Routledge, 2026.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Black Masters: A Study on Slave-owning Slaves, 1790–1850, Pernambuco, Brazil.” In *Slave Subjectivities in the Iberian Worlds (16th–20th Centuries)*, edited by Ângela Barreto Xavier, Cristina Nogueira da Silva, and Michel Cahen, 158–175. Leiden/Boston: Brill, 2024. Slave-owning Slaves
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “A Igreja e a Escravidão.” In *O que disse a Imprensa sobre a Escravidão no Brasil: fontes e propostas didáticas para a sala de aula*, vol. 2, 84–90. São Gonçalo: Editora Igualdade, 2024.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Escravidão e lugares de memória negra em Olinda.” In *Lugares de Memória da Escravidão e da Cultura Negra em Pernambuco*, edited by Isabel Cristina Martins Guillen, 95–114. Recife: CEPE, 2023.
- Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Resistência negra no Brasil: novas perspectivas.” In *Diferença étnico-racial e Educação Profissional, Científica e Tecnológica no Sertão Pernambucano*, 41–64. Alagoas: Editora Olyver, 2021.

Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Os Escravos Brancos de São Bento: Crioulização e Reprodução Endógena nas Propriedades Beneditinas, Pernambuco, séculos XVIII e XIX.” In *África e Brasil: culturas híbridas, identidades plurais*, 175–190. Salvador: EDUFBA, 2019.

Costa, Robson Pedrosa. “Entre o Santo e batuque: os escravos de São Bento sob a Regra do Glorioso Patriarca. Pernambuco, séculos XVIII e XIX.” In *Religiões Negras no Brasil: da escravidão à Pós-Abolição*, edited by Flávio Gomes and Valéria Gomes Costa, 41–58. São Paulo: Selo Negro Edições, 2016.

RESEARCH LEADERSHIP & INTERNATIONAL NETWORKS

Women Slavery Research Network

Co-Coordinator with Eugénia Rodrigues, 2026–present

International network promoting interdisciplinary, comparative, connected, and transnational research on women and girls subjected to slavery, compulsory labour, dependency, forced migration, and other forms of exploitation across multiple world regions.

Women of Africa, Women of the Diaspora

Principal Investigator, 2025–present

International CNPq-funded research network connecting Brazilian and international researchers working on women, slavery, gender, diaspora, resistance, and freedom.

Studies on Women of Africa and the Diaspora

Emerging International Research Network, 2026–present

Initiative under development to connect researchers working on African and Afro-descendant women across Africa, Brazil, Latin America, the Caribbean, and the wider diaspora.

CONFERENCE & RESEARCH EVENT ORGANISATION

2nd International Conference Women and Slavery: Violence, Resistance and Diasporas

Co-Organizer, 2026 | University of Lisbon

International Conference Women and Slavery in Africa and America: A Comparative Approach

Co-Organizer, 2024 | Centre for History, University of Lisbon

Trajetórias Atlânticas / Atlantic Trajectories Lecture Series

Co-Organizer, 2025–2026 | International online lecture series

Escravidão, Gênero e Tráfico no Mundo Atlântico (séculos XVIII e XIX)

Co-Organizer, 2025

CONFERENCE PAPERS, INVITED TALKS & ACADEMIC PRESENTATIONS, 2022–PRESENT

2026. “The First Free Womb: Slavery, Motherhood, and Gradual Emancipation on Benedictine Estates, Brazil, 1866–1871.” 2nd International Conference Women and Slavery: Violence, Resistance and Diasporas, University of Lisbon, Portugal, 2–3 June.

2026. “Escravidão, Maternidade e Liberdade nas Propriedades Beneditinas, Brasil, 1866–1871.” 18th Congress of the Brazilian Studies Association (BRASA), Salvador, Brazil.

2025. “Slaves of Religion: A Connected History between Portugal, Brazil and Africa.” World Christianity Studies & Asymmetrical Dependency (WCSAD), University of Bonn, Germany. Invited online lecture.

2025. “Com carícias e afagos: as várias faces do concubinato em propriedades beneditinas do Brasil, século XVII ao XIX.” Seminário Internacional Companheiras ou Propriedade: Concubinato e Escravidão no Mundo Luso-Atlântico, University of São Paulo (USP), Brazil, 19–20 May.

2025. “Os ‘escravos brancos’ de São Bento: maternidade, casamento e mestiçagem nas fazendas beneditinas, séculos XVII, XVIII e XIX.” 12º Encontro Escravidão e Liberdade, Federal University of Santa Catarina, Florianópolis, Brazil, 24–27 September.

2024. “Escravos senhores de escravos: histórias sobre ‘subversão hierárquica’ em África e na América.” Seminário CH-ULisboa História de África, Centre for History, University of Lisbon, Portugal. Invited lecture.

2024. “Uma eugenia astuciosa: miscigenação, crioulização e escravidão no Brasil. O caso das Ordens religiosas.” Race and Slavery Narratives in the European Colonial Empires: Interdisciplinary Approaches (15th–20th Centuries), University of Cabo Verde, Cabo Verde.

2024. With Eugénia Rodrigues and C. Grawitz. “Marie Skłodowska-Curie Postdoctoral Fellowships Call (MSCA PF).” EURAXESS Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC). Webinar.

2024. “História e Memória Quilombola: uma proposta inovadora de preservação, desenvolvimento sustentável e educação antirracista.” 4º Encontro Memória para Todos: Memória para Sustentabilidade, Territórios e Comunidades, NOVA University Lisbon, Portugal, June.
2024. “A Maternidade Negociada: uma história sobre corpo, controle e moralização de mulheres negras escravizadas.” Uma História de Silêncios? Colóquio CH-ULisboa de História das Mulheres e Género, University of Lisbon, Portugal, June.
2024. “Moralization, Indoctrination and Freedom: The Emancipationist Projects of the Benedictines, Brazil, 1780–1871.” Imagining Emancipation in the Atlantic World, 1750–1888, University of Copenhagen, Denmark, June.
2024. “Motherhood, Family and Resistance: The History of Enslaved Women Who Owned Slaves, Brazil, 18th and 19th Centuries.” International Conference Women and Slavery in Africa and America: A Comparative Approach, University of Lisbon, Portugal, 4–5 July.
2024. “A Moralização dos Costumes: um estudo sobre encontros e desencontros entre beneditinos e escravizados, Brasil, séculos XVIII e XIX.” XLIII Meeting of the Portuguese Association of Economic and Social History (APHES), Lisbon, Portugal, 15–16 November.
2024. “Cartas sobre la libertad: protestas, proyectos y discursos sobre la esclavitud en Brasil.” Réseaux de correspondances dans les mondes ibériques et ibéro-américains (XVIIIe–XIXe–XXe siècles), Université Toulouse–Jean Jaurès, France, 26–29 November.
2023. “Escravos da Religião: Paternalismo e Resistência, Brasil.” CTROP – Colégio Tropical, University of Lisbon. Webinar.
2023. “Connected Histories: Belonging, Autonomy and Freedom in the African Diaspora. The Case of Quilombola Communities in Brazil.” European Conference on African Studies (ECAS2023: African Futures), University of Cologne, Germany.
2023. With Marcos P. P. Costa. “Escravidão, Maternidade e Resistência Feminina no Brasil: subsídios didáticos para uma educação antirracista.” International Conference: The Lusophone World and its Diasporas, York University, Canada. Online presentation.
2023. “Diáspora, Memória e Reparação: uma Proposta Inovadora de Turismo de Base Comunitária.” IV International Congress of the Association of Brazilianists in Europe (ABRE), Iscte – University Institute of Lisbon, Portugal, 5–8 September.
2023. “Mom Told Me All About Her Ancestors: Mother’s Memories, Belonging and Refusal of Slavery, Congo, c. 1930–1957.” Resistance to Slavery in Africa: Past and Present, SOAS University of London, United Kingdom.
2022. “Mothers of Slavery: Procreation, Motherhood, and Black Women Resistance in Pernambuco Sugar Mills, 1790–1871.” 11th Iberian Congress of African Studies (CIEA11), Portugal.

GRADUATE SUPERVISION – SELECTED

Aristildes Morais da Silva Neto

MA in History, UFPE, 2025 | Supervisor

Entre o mel da cana e o gosto amargo do cativeiro: trajetórias, famílias e comunidades de escravizados na Vila de Ceará-Mirim (1854–1888).

Elida Nathalia Olimpio da Silva

MA in History, UFPE, 2025 | Supervisor

Terra de engenhos: economia e sociedade escravista na Comarca de Paudalho oitocentista.

Hygor Francisco Carvalho Gonçalves

MA in History, UFPE, 2021 | Supervisor

Research on wet nurses, everyday life, and representations in late nineteenth-century Recife.

Raphaela Ferreira Gonçalves

PhD in History, UFPE, 2020 | Co-Supervisor

Research on enslaved Black women and female resistance in nineteenth-century Pernambuco.

TEACHING

Current Teaching – Instituto Federal de Brasília

Scientific Research Methodology

Extension Activities / Community Engagement

Areas of Teaching Expertise

Brazilian History · History of Slavery · Atlantic History · African and Afro-Brazilian History · Gender History · Historical Research Methods

PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT, KNOWLEDGE EXCHANGE & DIGITAL HUMANITIES

Conexões Atlânticas / Atlantic Connections

Digital public-history initiative, 2023–present

Dedicated to African and Afro-descendant history and culture through digital dissemination and public history.

Dona Isabel, que História é essa? Slavery, Black Experiences and Resistance in Pernambuco

Coordinator, 2021–2023 | Technical cooperation with Fundação Joaquim Nabuco (FUNDAJ)

Public history and science-communication initiative transforming research on African and Afro-descendant history into freely accessible digital products.

History, Memory and Innovation: Anti-Racist Education, Ancestral Knowledge and Digital Technologies

FACEPE-funded initiative, 2022–2023

Integrated historical research, digital technologies, ethnic-racial education, heritage, and engagement with Black and traditional communities.

Malungo – Laboratory of Digital Humanities and Social Innovation

Coordinator, 2021–2022

Institutional laboratory dedicated to digital humanities, innovation, public history, and educational experimentation.

PROFESSIONAL ASSOCIATIONS

Black Women's Studies Association (BWSA) · Brazilian Studies Association (BRASA) · Marie Curie Alumni Association (MCAA) · Associação de Brazilianistas na Europa (ABRE) · Lusophone Studies Association (LSA) · Latin American and Caribbean Section of the Southern Historical Association (LACS-SHA) · Conference on Latin American History (CLAH)

LANGUAGES

Portuguese

Native

English

Advanced working proficiency

ACADEMIC PROFILE

Lattes Curriculum: <http://lattes.cnpq.br/6375934645076409>